

COPPERFIELD & CO.

A MUSICAL

BY

FRANK KIRWAN

*Based on “David Copperfield” by
Charles Dickens*

Cast in order of appearance

David Copperfield (Narrator, as an old man)

Uriah Heep (Narrator, as an old man)

David Copperfield (boy)

Peggotty

Mr Murdstone

Clara Copperfield

Miss Murdstone

Mr Mell

Boys 1,2 and 3

Mr Creakle

Workman

Boys in Bottle Factory

Mr Micawber

Mrs Micawber

Maid

Aunt Betsy

Mr Dick

Mr Wickfield

Agnes Wickfield

Uriah Heep

Micawber Junior

Little Boy

Scenes

Act One

Scene 1- Narrators

Scene 2 - the Copperfield residence

Scene 3 – the Copperfield residence

Scene 4 – a classroom

Scene 5 – the Copperfield residence

Scene 6 – the Bottle Factory

Scene 7 – the Micawber residence

Scene 8 – Aunt Betsy's residence

Scene 9 - the Wickfield residence

Scene 10 – the Wickfield residence

Act Two

Scene 1 – the Wickfield residence

Scene 2 – the Micawber residence

Scene 3 – the Wickfield residence

Scene 4 – the Micawber residence

Scene 5 – Aunt Betsy's residence

Scene 6 – the Wickfield residence

Scene 7 – the Wickfield residence

Scene 8 – a street

Order of Songs

Act One

David	Clara Copperfield
This Boy	Mr and Miss Murdstone
All alone am I	David Copperfield (boy)
He bites	Mr Creakle
Bottle Boys	Chorus
Something will turn up	Mr Micawber and family
David (reprise)	Chorus (with Clara Copperfield)
I'm 'umble	Uriah Heep
Angel in the morning	Agnes Wickfield

Act Two

Just time for another	Mr Wickfield and Uriah Heep
Reasons	Agnes Wickfield
False veracity	Mr Micawber and Uriah Heep
Matrimony	Uriah Heep and chorus
Wish I'd never seen the sunshine	David Copperfield (adult) and Clara Copperfield
Crazy	Mr Dick
Evidence	Mr Wickfield, Mr Micawber, Uriah Heep, the policemen (and chorus)
Only Love	Uriah Heep and chorus
Angel in the morning (reprise)	David Copperfield (adult), Agnes Wickfield and chorus
Copperfield and Company	Uriah Heep and David Copperfield (narrators) and entire cast

SCENE ONE - THE NARRATORS (DAVID AND URIAH AS OLD MEN)

DAVID: A Merry Christmas, Uriah!

URIAH: And a very Happy Christmas to you, my old friend!

DAVID: Old indeed, Uriah, but well contented and hopeful of another successful year to come for the old firm of Copperfield and Heep.

URIAH: Oh, please, David, Copperfield and Company, Copperfield and Company. You know very well that in this firm your name is all that is needed. I'm quite happy to remain the most silent of silent partners.

DAVID: Still humble, Uriah?

URIAH: **(laughing):** Ever so 'umble, Master Copperfield, ever so 'umble, sir!

DAVID: **(laughs):** You weren't so humble once, I seem to remember. How long is it since we patched up our differences?

URIAH: Twenty years to this very day since I saw the light, David, but how many years of misery before that, I wonder?

DAVID: You didn't have a monopoly on misery in those days, Uriah. We've both had topsy-turvy times, and what about some of the others we've known – the Wickfields, the Micawbers, Aunt Betsy and Mr Dick, Peggotty my old nurse – it all seems such a long time ago.....such a long time.

URIAH: Such a long time indeed. It takes me back, too. More cognac, David?

DAVID: Your good health my old friend!

URIAH: I'll give you a toast, David, a Christmas toast. To days gone by!

DAVID: To days gone by, Uriah, ...days gone by...days gone by.

(“DAVID” THEME IS HEARD AS WE DRIFT INTO THE PAST)

SCENE TWO - DAVID (THE BOY), PEGGOTTY

DAVID: Peggotty were you ever married?

PEGGOTTY: Now Master David, whatever turned your little head to thoughts of marriage? An ordinary person like me has no time to worry about such things as marriage.

DAVID: It's...it's just that I thought you a very handsome woman and wondered why you weren't married.

PEGGOTTY: Me, handsome? Dear oh dear, I do think you might be exaggerating my charms a bit, David. But why all this sudden talk about marriage? Come on, out with it.

DAVID: I'm scared, Peggotty. Ever since my father died we've seen an awful lot of that Mr Murdstone. It worries me – I know he's always polite and that my mother finds him so charming, but I don't like the look of him at all - do you think he might want to marry her?

PEGGOTTY: He does seem a bit full of himself at times, David, it's true, though I shouldn't be saying it, but it's nothing you should worry your little head about. Your mother's looking for somebody strong that she can rely on, now your father's gone. But as for getting married, well I don't know about that and I'm sure she doesn't either. Anyway, let's get back to more cheerful things. Tell me more about those corkondrills of yours.

DAVID: Corkondrills?

PEGGOTTY: You know those horrible things in your book about the jungle.

DAVID: Oh, you mean crocodiles.

PEGGOTTY: That's what I said ...corkondriles.

ENTER – MR MURDSTONE AND CLARA. DAVID RUNS TO CLARA AND PUTS HIS RIGHT ARM AROUND HER.

MR M'STONE: I'll just say goodnight to this fine, fine boy of yours, Clara. Come, my lad, we'll be the best friends in all of the world. Shake hands, Master Copperfield.

CLARA: Come on David, shake hands with Mr Murdstone. **(David clings to Clara and offers his left hand)**

MR M'STONE: **(annoyed):** Come along now lad, this won't do. That's the wrong hand. Give me the other, boy. **(Changes tone)** Come along, now, there's a good lad... Oh well this one will have to do ... What a fine fellow he is to be sure, but we may perhaps have to teach him one or two things about the manners of a gentleman.

PEGGOTTY: Oh, David can be very well mannered when he tries, Mr Murdstone, can't you David?

DAVID: Yes, Peggotty.

MR M'STONE: Well that's as may be, but in any event my dearest Clara, I must bid you goodnight and thank you for yet another pleasant evening. Don't worry, I know my way out. I'm becoming very familiar with this house and, hopefully soon, I'll be even more familiar! Goodnight everybody, and may God in his heaven bless you all.

EXIT MR. MURDSTONE

CLARA: That wasn't very polite, David, you know. How could you let me down like that in front of Mr Murdstone?

DAVID: I know you like him, mother, but I'm not sure about Mr Murdstone. He makes me think the happiness we have together will disappear. It feels like he's taking you away from me. Father's gone. Will you go, too?

CLARA: Oh, David, Mr Murdstone's been such a help to me these last few months. You could never know how hard it's been since your father died. But you, of all people, should know that no-one could ever, ever come between the two of us. I'll always, always be with you.

DAVID: I know that, but after father, well... I just worry.

SONG: DAVID SUNG BY CLARA COPPERFIELD

TO NARRATORS:

URIAH: You received a great deal of love, David, in your early life.

DAVID: Love which was to strengthen me in years to come and sustain my faith in mankind when all seemed lost. I will always value the early love of my mother and Peggotty. But what of your childhood, Uriah?

URIAH: Much the opposite, I fear, for I learned only two things from my mother. How to cheat and how to be 'umble and thus make cheating easier. And from an early age dishonesty became part and parcel of my very existence ... but you David, you hadn't seen the last of Mr Murdstone.

DAVID: No, Uriah, for within months he'd wormed his way into our household, having finally won the hand of my loving but oh so vulnerable mother. But, even worse, he managed to persuade her to dispense with my old friend Peggotty and install in her place his loathsome sister as my unforgiving personal tutor.

SCENE THREE - DAVID, CLARA, THE MURDSTONES

(CLARA & DAVID SEATED AT A TABLE, WORKING. THE MURDSTONES, AT THE OTHER SIDE OF THE STAGE, OUT OF THEIR HEARING.)

MISS M'STONE: James, as you well know, I am the very model of patience. I cannot suffer this fool of a boy for one moment longer. He is a wretch.

MR M'STONE: Hm, a wretch, a brainless wretch, and impolite into the bargain, but do not worry sister, I have the matter totally in hand.

MISS M'STONE: We must rid ourselves of this aimless urchin and his pathetic mother at our earliest opportunity. Time is ripe, James, time is ripe for the seizing of their inheritance.

MR M'STONE: Time is ripe, sister, let us strike while the iron is hot, let us interrogate the boy, let us question him.

MISS M'STONE: Question him, question him, I shall question him.

(THEY WALK OVER TO CLARA AND DAVID)

MISS M'STONE: What is seven times seven, boy?

DAVID: Er ...

MR M'STONE: Chop, chop, young man, no hesitation.

MISS M'STONE: The boy is an imbecile. Simple tables are a complete mystery to him. What is six times twelve, boy?

DAVID: Er ...

MR M'STONE: Y're too slow boy, **(slowly)** you see you are excruciatingly, excruciatingly slow.

MISS M'STONE: This child learns nothing in spite of my meticulous tuition. He is incompetent.

MR. M'STONE: Incompetent, totally incompetent.

CLARA: Come, David, think! Oh give him a little more time James.

MISS M'STONE: Time? Clara, time is of the essence and time must not be wasted on simple problems with his tables. The boy is a lazy wretch.

CLARA: Oh no, he tries, he really tries.

MR M'STONE: No, no, come, come Clara, do not be soft, this boy needs tough handling, or he will never come to heel. This boy will eventually learn to do things my way.

SONG: THIS BOY (SUNG BY THE MURDSTONES)

AT END OF SONG DAVID BITES MR MURDSTONE

MR M'STONE: The boy bites, my dear, the boy bites.

CLARA: Oh David, how could you do such a thing. Oh James, he didn't mean it. He'll apologise. Come David, please say you're sorry.

MISS M'STONE: Cease your simpering Clara. If the boy bites it only goes to prove, as I suspected, that he has the brains of a dog. If he acts like a dog, he must be trained like a dog. Put him in the kennels, send him to boarding school.

CLARA: No! James, please, no!

MR M'STONE: To school, sister, and I know of a school that'll teach him well.

MISS M'STONE: Salem House, Mr.Creakle.

MR M'STONE: Salem House in Blackheath.

MISS M'STONE: The teachers are hard in Blackheath.

MR M'STONE: The teachers are mean in Blackheath.

CLARA: No! No!

MISS M'STONE: It's settled. I shall make the arrangements. He shall start next week.

MR M'STONE: Come, Clara, let us take tea and let us leave this child on his own for a while to contemplate his glorious academic future.

(THE MURDSTONES USHER CLARA OUT OF THE ROOM)

SONG: ALL ALONE AM I (SUNG BY DAVID)

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: So the shadows were indeed falling fast as I in my own childish eyes foresaw. The little I saw of my mother was to dwindle even further and my term time life now centred on Salem House, as cheap an educational establishment as one was likely to find. Run by a tyrant called Creakle it could hardly have been a greater contrast to the education I had once received from the kindly Peggotty and her corkondrile books.

SCENE FOUR - MR MELL AND A CLASS OF SCHOOLBOYS

A CLASSROOM. THE STARTING IMAGE IS THAT OF AN ORDERLY CLASS SEATED AND UNDERGOING AN OLD FASHIONED MATHEMATICS LESSON. THE TEACHER HAS HIS BACK TO THE CLASS.

MR MELL: And the final answer to this equation proves to be, as I hope you indeed have found, having managed to follow my extremely patient and detailed explanation, as you undoubtedly...

(THE BOYS START TO THROW BALLS OF PAPER AT EACH OTHER AND ONE OF THEM FLIES PAST OR HITS THE TEACHER)

MR MELL: Who threw that?

(NO REPLY, MUMBLED ACCUSATIONS)

MR MELL: Now come on, I need to know who threw that. If I don't find out 'll...it'll...er...there will be serious consequences!

BOYS: Ooh!

BOY ONE: Sir, I cannot tell a lie, sir I have to admit that it was I who committed this abomination.

BOY TWO: No it wasn't sir, it was me.

BOY ONE: Are you calling me a...

BOY THREE: It was neither of them sir, it was me.

ALL BOYS: It was me, me, it was me sir

(GENERAL CHAOS, WITH MORE PAPER BALLS AND LOTS OF NOISE)

ENTER MR CREAKLE, WITH DAVID

MR CREAKLE: Whaaat!!! Do I hear noise within the hallowed walls of one of my sanctums of study? Well I'll not have it. Take this sir, and that sir, and this sir, and how about this sir **(lays about the class with a cane, at one stage accidentally hitting Mr Mell, who follows him around the classroom)**.

(SILENCE)

MR CREAKLE: Now. Let me introduce you, furthermore, to a new member of our elite academy, one David Copperfield esquire. I must warn you that, meek and mild as this waif of a child may look, his bite is much worse than his bark. Observe.

(HE TURNS DAVID ROUND TO DISPLAY THE SIGN "HE BITES" IN LARGE LETTERS PINNED TO HIS BACK).

MR CREAKLE: Indeed, let me offer you fellows a few words of advice as to your esteemed new colleague.

SONG: HE BITES (SUNG BY MR CREAKLE AND THE CHORUS)

AT THE END OF THE SONG THE VISUAL IMAGE IS THE SAME AS THAT AT THE START OF THE SCENE.

TO NARRATORS:

URIAH: A poor excuse for an education, David, but at least it was an education. You were better off than many!

DAVID: A short and not wholly productive spell of education, for, several months later I was coldly and factually informed by this same headmaster that my mother had caught a chill and that, as this chill had developed into pneumonia, she had sadly died.

URIAH: You received no warning?

DAVID: And I was to receive no comfort. Whisked away from school, I was coldly asked to attend the funeral and then became the unwanted property of Mr Murdstone.

URIAH: Who, of course, would have inherited much more useful effects from your dear mother.

DAVID: And so very soon I was to be summoned to a council of war, which was to decide my future.

SCENE FIVE - MR & MISS MURDSTONE, DAVID

DAVID IS SEATED AT A TABLE. THE MURDSTONES LOOK STERN, AS INTERVIEWING THE YOUNG COPPERFIELD

MR M'STONE: And so, Master Copperfield, what ambitions do you have for the future?

DAVID: Ambitions sir?

MISS M'STONE: Ambitions, boy, what do you intend to do with your life?

DAVID: I... I have no idea, Miss Murdstone.

MISS M'STONE: No idea, no idea, James, this boy becomes duller by the minute.

MR M'STONE: Yes, my dear, I concur. This boy is incredibly dim.

MISS M'STONE: And his most expensive education with Mr Creakle has obviously had no effect. What is seven times four boy?

DAVID: Twenty ...

MR M'STONE: **(Before he gets time to answer):** You're too slow boy! Far too slow! No effect. No effect whatsoever. Therefore, there is no alternative my dear. Education is of no use to a dullard like this. There's only one answer. Hard work. We shall send him to my bottle factory in London where he shall produce some hard labour.

SCENE SIX - THE BOTTLE FACTORY. DAVID, WITH WORKMAN

WORKMAN: **(Strong London accent)!** You're flamin' early ain't yer, mate? You must be a new boy! I bet this won't last. The others 'll be here soon. Let's have a look at yer hands. Gawd, look how new and smooth they are – we'll soon rough 'em up, we'll soon get a bit of good old London dirt into your frame, you've got a lot to learn, my son. Chin up, mate, it ain't all that bad. Look, ere's your oppos.

ENTER BOTTLE BOYS, WHISTLING BOTTLE BOYS' SONG, PARADE AROUND THE STAGE AND AROUND DAVID, CONFUSING HIM.

BOY: Who're you then, mate? Come for a little visit 'av we? Come to see how the other 'alf live?

DAVID: I'm David Copperfield, from Blunderstone, near Yarmouth, and I've come to work here as a b...bottle boy?

BOY: Oh, David Copperfield, from Blunderstone, near Yarmouth, a...b bottle boy?

ALL B. BOYS: Oh, David Copperfield from Blunderstone, near Yarmouth, a...b bottle boy?

BOY: **(Posh accent):** Oh really, jolly good old chap. **(then normal accent)** Well listen 'ere, Master Copperfield, you my son, are going to become a honorary bottle boy as from today and if you are going to become one of us, then you've got a few little lessons to learn fast. Us bottle boys is gonna 'ave to teach you real sharpish like, otherwise you have no chance of survivin in this 'ere metrop.

DAVID: Metrop?

BOY: Metrop? Metrop? Metropolis, my son. London, where the streets are paved wiv gold, though I ain't seen none yet. 'Ere, can you landle a bottle? **(Throws one at David, who fumbles, but catches it).** Not bad. Drop that and there goes a full week's wages.

DAVID: Really. And how much would that be?

BOY: A full sixpence, no less! Listen mate, **(brings David close)** never drop your bottle

(the others laugh), and, whatever ‘appens, don t lose your bottle **(more laughter)**.

DAVID: Why?

BOY: Cos, when you've lost your bottle... listen, don't worry, mate, we'll look after you. We'll show you how to become a real bottle boy. Watch this.

SONG: BOTTLE BOYS (SUNG BY THE CHORUS)

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: And so, all a sudden, I was a bottle boy. Or should I say I were a bottle boy, for my accent changed, my outlook changed and my attitudes changed. And what’s more. My education into worldly affairs was furthered by my lodging with a certain family who were destined to play a never to be forgotten part in the story of my life, a family continually it seemed, haunted by the twin spectres of poverty and debt.

URIAH: And yet a family continually living in hope and anticipation that times would change for the better, and that in the fullness of time, in short, ...

DAVID & URIAH: Something would turn up!

SCENE SEVEN - THE MICAWBERS’ HOUSE. MRS MICAWBER AND (LOTS OF) CHILDREN

ENTER: MR MICAWBER

MR MICAWBER: Ah, Copperfield, home from the war - home from the industrial front! How goes it in the esteemed trade of the embottlement of alcoholic substances? Are you making healthy progress? Are you promoted yet to a managerial capacity?

DAVID: Not yet, sir **(he sounds more self assured, now)** Unfortunately my talents, as yours, remain still unrecognized. I am yet a mere factory floor worker, a bottle boy, as before.

MR MICAWBER: How often talent lies unrecognized until it is too late. But be encouraged, young Copperfield, we are like wells yet to be discovered, with depths of achievement as yet untapped, but I do not give up hope and nor must you! Something will turn up, something will turn up.

MRS MICAWBER: David, sit down at the table, we've got a surprise in store, tonight, haven't we children?

CHILDREN: Yes, mother.

MR MICAWBER: A repast fit for a reigning monarch, Copperfield. A banquet befitting to the benevolent despot whom I profess to be.

DAVID: Pardon, sir?

MR MICAWBER: Food, Copperfield. The condemned man ate a hearty breakfast, or in this case, a hearty supper. For tonight the feast ...tomorrow **(melodramatically)** Wilkins Micawber takes residence, albeit temporarily, at Kings Bench Debtors' Prison.

DAVID: You seem only a trifle worried Mrs Micawber?

MRS MICAWBER: That is because, David, Mr Micawber, as I do, knows, in his heart of hearts, that in time, for a man of his talents, something will at last turn up and our troubles will be over.

MR MICAWBER: Indeed, my dear, genius will ultimately gain its just reward. Micawber is going, I repeat temporarily, into voluntary liquidation. But drink some punch, Copperfield, let us take courage, for ...

SONG: SOMETHING WILL TURN UP (SUNG BY MR MICAWBER AND FAMILY)

END OF SONG: LOUD KNOCKS ON DOOR. SHOUTING FROM OUTSIDE

VOICES: Micawber, Micawber, we know you're in there! ...We want our money. If you don't come out we're comin' in...Micawber, I want you before the law does. You owe me.

CONTINUED BANGING ON DOOR

MR MICAWBER: **(Kisses wife, children, shakes hands with Copperfield):** Apologies for hasty departure, Copperfield. Must take fresh air. Feel... a bit faint. Walk on the roof an inspiring thought. Don't wait up for me, my dear, I may be some time. **(Exit)**

VOICES OUTSIDE: There he goes, on the roof. Chase him... Grab him... Stop, thief... Micawber, you cheatin' ...

ALL WATCH WHAT IS HAPPENING OFF STAGE

CHILDREN: Run, father, quick, run! Hurray! ooh! Oh not again!

MRS MICAWBER: Don't worry about Wilkins, David, he's been in much worse scrapes than this and survived. But what about you, David? You must find other lodgings. We'll have to move out of here by tomorrow. Have you anywhere you can go?

DAVID: There's nowhere, at least nowhere I'd want to go in London, after the love you've given me here. It seems every time I'm happy, my happiness is snatched away from me. I do have an aunt who lives in Dover, but that seems like the other end of the world. It just seems too far.

MRS MICAWBER: **(Melodramatically, after the fashion of Micawber):** But you must try, David, nothing will happen, unless you make it happen and some people have to try harder than others. But you, like Mr Micawber, will make it in the long run. Don't worry about the past, think of the future and go out and find that silver lining. We Micawbers are a tough breed. We'll survive.

(IN BACKGROUND VOICE OF CLARA SINGING THE FIRST LINES OF “DAVID”)

DAVID: **(to front of stage):** Oh, mother, I never missed you as much as I do now. I just feel so alone again. If you're there, please help me and tell me what to do. **(hesitates and thinks as lights go down)**

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: And so the end of my days as a bottle boy had come and yet again I was due for a change of circumstances. So I made my way to Dover, though the road was long and fraught with danger for a young boy all on his own. But the words of my mother stayed in my mind throughout the journey and, as I looked up into the night sky, I somehow knew that eventually she would guide me to a new home. And, though my aunt didn't like the look of the dreadful urchin who arrived on her doorstep, she bathed me, fed me, clothed me and, with no hesitation, accepted me into the home which she shared with her strange but true cousin, who would be forever known to me as Mr Dick.

SCENE EIGHT - AUNT BETSY'S HOUSE, DAVID, AUNT BETSY, MR DICK

AUNT BETSY: You must show David your kite, Mr Dick.

MR DICK: My kite, ah yes, my kite! **(Runs off stage, singing).** My kite, my lovely kite, the kite I fly by day and by night.

DAVID: I like Mr Dick, Aunt Betsy, but isn't he a bit strange?

AUNT BETSY: David, let me tell you one thing. Never underestimate Mr Dick. He may seem a little unlike other people you know, but he is a tower of strength to me and, when it comes down to it, he's sharper than any other man I know. **(Knock on the door)** Now who could that be at this hour?

ENTER MAID

MAID: A Mr and Miss Murdstone to see you, madam.

ENTER THE MURDSTONES, UNINVITED, PUSHING THE MAID OUT OF THE WAY

MR M'STONE: Ah, Miss Betsy Trotwood, I believe. Madam, I have it on good authority that you have that young scoundrel David Copperfield on your premises. I'll have you know that I regard this as abduction of the boy.

MISS M'STONE: Abduction of the boy! Abduction of the boy!

MR M'STONE: And furthermore I'll have you know that the boy must be returned forthwith to the bottle factory from whence he came – he has valuable work to be done.

MISS M'STONE: Valuable work to be done! Valuable work to be done!

AUNT BETSY: Mr Murdstone, I take great exception ...

MR DICK RUNS BACK ON STAGE

- MR DICK: My kite, my kite, by day, by night, I fly my kite. I fly my kite, I always ...fly my...kite.**(slows down as he meets the Murdstones)**. Good morning sir, good morning, madam. **(bows with a flourish)**
- MR M'STONE: I'll have you know, sir, that it's five o'clock in the afternoon. You not only look a fool. You are a fool.
- MISS M'STONE: Not only looks a fool. He is a fool.
- AUNT BETSY: I beg your pardon, sir, madam. This fool, I shall have you know, shall decide what is to be done with the boy David Copperfield. It shall be his decision.
- MR M'STONE: But, but this is absurd ...
- MISS M'STONE: Absurd! Absurd!
- AUNT BETSY: Mr Dick, think, what shall we do with this boy. Come now, this is of vital importance.
- MR DICK: I should...**(Murdstones approach)** ...no! no! no!
- (MURDSTONES RETREAT)**
- MR DICK: I should...**(Murdstones approach again)** ...no! no! no!
- (MURDSTONES RETREAT)**
- MR DICK: I should ...I should ...I should buy him a suit of clothes, but first, ...I should take him to fly my kite!!
- AUNT BETSY: Nothing clearer could be said. I entirely concur with your judgement. Mr Dick, the boy shall stay.
- MR DICK: Hurray, hurray, the boy shall stay, hurray, hurray...
- MR M'STONE: What, with you and this, this imbecile?
- MISS M'STONE: Imbecile, imbecile.
- AUNT BETSY: What! that's it! that's it! get out of my house sir, and take this overgrown parrot of a sister with you!
- MISS M'STONE: What a rude, offensive woman, James.
- AUNT BETSY: Where's my walking stick? **(Picks up her walking stick)**! I'll give you rude and offensive. Now, out, Madam Parrot, out, Mr Bully.
- MR M'STONE: **(Retreating fast)**! You shall hear from our solicitors, madam, have no doubt of that.
- AUNT BETSY: Out! Out!
- MISS M'STONE: Madame your manners are ...ouch! such!

MR M'STONE: I'll have you know that constitutes assault and... ouch! ouch! ...battery ...ouch! ouch!

EXIT MURDSTONES

AUNT BETSY: Well that's the end of those two demons.

DAVID: **(Re-emerging):** Are you sure, Aunt Betsy?

AUNT BETSY: Positive. They'll not be back, I know a bluffer when I see one. There's nothing he can gain from pursuing you any further. They'll not be back, and now you've a whole new world calling you, young David, you've a lot of childhood to catch up on and there are two people ready and willing to help you live it to the full, eh Mr Dick?

MR DICK: Er to the full, quite definitely to the full !

SONG (IN BACKGROUND AS DAVID TAKES CENTRE STAGE): REPRISE OF FINAL VERSE OF "DAVID", SUNG BY CHORUS

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: And so, a new world, and a childhood, and an education and the end, for a while, to my troubles. But childhood, as we both now know, Uriah, is a brief sojourn and its end was to signal the beginning of our unpredictable relationship, was it not? Well I remember the day that my aunt introduced me into the employ of one Mr Wickfield in whose household both you and I were to be articled clerks.

URIAH: Indeed, David, I was, I believe, at this stage, at the height of my humility period, was I not?

DAVID: Not quite the height, but building up to it, my friend...building up to it ...

SCENE NINE - THE WICKFIELDS' RESIDENCE

AUNT BETSY, DICK, DAVID (ADULT). AGNES, MR WICKFIELD, HEEP (WORKING AT HIS DESK, CONTINUALLY SCOWLING IN THE AUDIENCE'S DIRECTION)

AUNT BETSY: David. May I introduce you to the man who is to guide your way in the legal profession, Mr. Wickfield and his daughter Agnes.

DAVID: Most charmed to meet your acquaintance, dear sir, and even more charmed, if that is possible, to meet that of your daughter.

MR WICKFIELD: Mr Copperfield.

AGNES: Mr Copperfield, or may I say David?

DAVID: Of course you may...Agnes.

AUNT BETSY: **(Looking down her nose at Heep):** And who, may I ask, is this?

MR WICKFIELD: This is my clerk, on whom, I may say, I tremendously rely, Mr Uriah Heep, who is also attempting at present to make himself a reputation in the legal business.

HEEP: **(Rising from his desk):** Mr Wickfield pays me too great a compliment. I am a mere clerk, and shall remain in that 'umble position. But may I say how utterly gratified I am that a 'umble personage such as I should be given the hopportunity to converse with your eminent selves. Good day Miss Trotwood. **(He kisses her hand and she recoils).** Good day sir **(he shakes hands with David and with Mr Dick. They both unconsciously wipe their hands on their trousers.)** Good day sir **(retires to his desk, pretending to work, but listening to the conversation).**

AUNT BETSY: What a strange character. Are you sure that David will progress adequately alongside someone like that?

MR WICKFIELD: Heep is strange, I employed him in the first instance, y'know, as a personal favour to his old mother, to whom I was for various reasons indebted. But whatever else, he's an extremely shrewd young man, and it's my opinion that he'll go far in this business. But come along, Miss Trotwood, we've a few odds and ends to sort out concerning David's future ...

AUNT BETSY: Yes, come along, David, come along, Mr Dick.

(EXIT ALL, BUT URIAH)

HEEP: Yuk! **(mimics the posh accent)** A few odds and ends to sort out. David Copperfield, David Copperfield, I've heard nothing but David flippin' Copperfield for the last month. And look how he fawns over my Agnes; but don't you worry Uriah, they who think you are 'umble are they who shall be made 'umble. **(to audience)** Do you doubt me sir, do you doubt me madam? Do not, for you may fall victim to the underestimated powers of the ever so, ever so 'umble Uriah Heep ...

SONG: I'M 'UMBLE SUNG BY URIAH HEEP

TO NARRATORS:

URIAH: Ever so 'umble indeed, David. Could I really have been so obnoxious, David? Was I that oily, greasy rogue all the time, or did I have periods of, so to speak, remittance?

DAVID: Very rarely, Uriah, did the present side of your character see the light in those days, I'm afraid your darker side was dominant, and only very occasionally did you relax and show your inner self. I do remember, however, one memorable night when an old friend came unexpectedly to call.

SCENE TEN – AGNES

AGNES READING AT THE DESK. ENTER DAVID

DAVID: Oh my head!, oh my head! Never again. Oh my head!

AGNES: Oh, well you can't say I didn't warn you, David.

DAVID: Agnes what was I doing last night? I've never felt so bad in my whole life.

AGNES: Well your old friend Mr Micawber said he'd just come round for some **(mimics Micawber)** "quiet, unobtrusive, philosophical yet meandering chit-chat of no great consequence", but you started on his rather dubious champagne and then between the two of you and Uriah you finished off most of my father's cocktail cabinet. In fact you all seemed to enjoy yourselves, especially Uriah, until....

DAVID: Until what?

AGNES: You don't remember **(laughs)**.

DAVID: No! Oh come on, Agnes, tell me, what have I done now?

AGNES: You don't remember he heard you instructing Mr Micawber that your mutual friend was to be henceforth called "His oiliness Uriah Heep", amongst other things that I wouldn't even dare mention.

DAVID: I didn't, did I **(perks up a bit)**?

AGNES: We all tried to shut you up. Uriah refused to take offence, but then you ...

DAVID: Yes?

AGNES: You spilt almost a whole decanter of port down the front of his favourite, or is it his only, jacket. He wasn't over pleased about it, I must admit, but it was funny watching him try to be angry and 'umble at the same time. Anyway, let's try to cure that head-ache **(starts to massage his forehead)**.

DAVID: Agnes, how is it you always manage to find a solution to everyone's problems?

AGNES: I don't. It's just your imagination. How does this feel?

DAVID: Marvellous, getting better already. Like a magic spell. Agnes, you really are like a guardian angel, you know. And it's on mornings like this that I really need a guardian angel. Ooh, I don't know about that head though on second thoughts.

SONG: ANGEL IN THE MORNING SUNG BY AGNES WICKFIELD

END OF SONG ENTER HEEP (IN STAINED JACKET)

HEEP: Good morning, Mr Copperfield, and Agnes, Miss Agnes, may I wish you the best of all mornings. **(tries to kiss her hand, misses, kisses his own hand)**.

AGNES: **(Giggling)**: You may wish me what you like, Uriah, but I must be going. I've some important business to attend to.

DAVID: I'll walk with you, Agnes. I could do with some fresh air after last night. It suddenly seems so stuffy in here.

AGNES: Yes, come on, let's go. It makes me feel a bit...oily.

DAVID: Bye Uriah.

AGNES: Bye Uriah **(both exit, laughing)**.

HEEP: Goodbye my dears, goodbye my sweet innocents. Enjoy your youth while you can. You think I don't know that you laugh in my face, that you consider me an ignorant, uncouth, uneducated nonentity? Well I have news for you, my friends. Uriah is and always has been a 'umble man, but there's more to Uriah than meets the eye, much more to Uriah than meets the eye and maybe, just maybe, there will come a time when you, Mr Copperfield sir and you, my dearest, dearest Miss Agnes, may find me not quite as 'umble as I used to be. Mark my words, just mark my words.

(INSTRUMENTAL REPRISE OF 'I'M UMBLE' CHORUS AS CURTAIN FALLS)

END OF ACT ONE

ACT TWO

THE NARRATORS:

- DAVID: So the scene had been set for our adult lives Uriah, and time flew by. My friendship with Agnes cemented, but for my part it was just that, friendship. Maybe I hurt Agnes by not reading more into it, but I regarded her at that time as a loving sister.
- URIAH: While I saw the lovely Agnes as a stepping stone for my greedy ambitions.
- DAVID: And this widened the ever increasing gulf between us, Uriah. Your scheming and the obvious success of some of your dubious financial dealings turned me very quickly against you, and, just as we are such good friends now, we soon became, though below the surface at first, bitter enemies.
- URIAH: And as I grew from strength to strength, Mr Wickfield moved from drink to drink and played, I fear, straight into my ever greedy little hands!

SCENE ONE - DAVID, AGNES, MR WICKFIELD, HEEP (AT TABLE)

- DAVID: **(finishes his cognac):** Goodness me, look at the time, I'd better get moving. I have a rather important assignment tonight. My business is booming, thanks to Mr Wickfield, but my clients become ever more demanding, fortunately for me!
- AGNES: Oh come on, David, be honest! We know where you're going.
- DAVID: I told you, I'm meeting a client... really! **(embarrassed)**
- AGNES: And... might that client be one Dora Spenlow?
- DAVID: Well...it might.
- AGNES: Aha...the lovely Dora. She's a very lucky lady!
- HEEP: Ah! Doral Dora! I adore'er. But lovely though she is, she is not half as lovely as you, my dearest, dearest Agnes. May I kiss your adorable hand in tribute to your impeccable, flawless beauty?
- DAVID: **(Glares at Heep):** Yes Uriah. Well, at any rate, I'd better get a move on.
- MR WICKFIELD: Oh come on, David, just time for another, eh, eh **(sounds drunk).**
- AGNES: Father, you've had quite enough already. I'll see David to the door and then I'm going to the drawing room to read for a while. Come along, David, and for goodness sake straighten your tie and look the part, or it'll be the last time you have the lovely Dora as your client.
- DAVID: Thanks Agnes, goodnight gentlemen.
- MR WICKFIELD: Goodnight David, cheers!

HEEP: Goodnight, Copperfield, goodnight, have a good time! have a splendid time!**(and, as DAVID AND AGNES EXIT)** I'm sure I will!
Now, come along Mr Wickfield, we've just time for another! Good! And perhaps, another. Marvellous, marvellous. You're in fine form tonight, sir. Er...
Mr Wickfield, while we are about it, there are one or two papers which need your official signature. Come, have another drink and we'll mix business with pleasure.

MR WICKFIELD: A capital idea Uriah, a capital idea. What a splendid fellow you are. Cheers! To Uriah, the only true friend I have, who stays when all the others are gone.

SONG: JUST TIME FOR ANOTHER

(SUNG BY WICKFIELD, WITH HEEP JOINING IN ON THE TITLE LINE AND THE CHORUS.) AT END OF EACH VERSE HEEP GOES OFF STAGE AND RETURNS WITH A FRESH BOTTLE, PREFERABLY A LARGER ONE EACH TIME.

(AT END OF SONG WICKFIELD FALLS INTO A DRUNKEN STUPOR, AND URIAH MANIPULATES HIS HAND).

HEEP: Please sign the documents sir, please sign the documents. **(Wickfield slumps)** Yes, here, and here, Mr Wickfield...thank you most, most kindly, my dear, dear sir.

RE-ENTER AGNES, UNSEEN BY HEEP SHE SEES HIM AND STAYS IN THE BACKGROUND. MR WICKFIELD HAS FALLEN ASLEEP

URIAH: Good night Wickfield, you old fool, and a good night to you, my stunningly beautiful bride to be, the lovely Miss Agnes Wickfield. **(Blows a kiss in the direction of the drawing room).** **(Yawns)** Ah well, I shall take this bit of business to bed with me. Nothing like a bit of business before bed, I always say.

(EXIT HEEP VIA ANOTHER DOOR)

AGNES: Ugh! Horrible man! Marry him? Repulsive toad! I think, in all honesty, I'd rather marry a toad.

Father **(shakes Wickfield)**, Father! Father! Oh, it's no good. Marriage to Heep. And the way things are going it may yet come to that. Oh David, David, if only you didn't see me as a sister. What's Dora got that I haven't? "Oh it's not like you to be jealous, Agnes"**(mocking)** That's what they'd all say. The noble Agnes, the fine Agnes, but sometimes I think I'd do anything, no matter what, to take Dora's place.

SONG: REASONS (SUNG BY AGNES)

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: If I remember rightly, Uriah, at this point in time, your liaisons were becoming many and varied. Besides the Wickfield situation, Mr Micawber was sinking deeper and deeper into the financial mire, and, with the debtors' prison yet again beckoning, it was to Uriah Heep, entrepreneur, that he turned in his final hour of need.

URIAH: My beneficence, as Micawber might say, was unbounded, my dear sir. Any waif or stray could come to my door in the hope of receiving the gracious benefit of my multi-purpose machinations. In short, I was always on the look out for an easy target.

SCENE TWO - THE MICAWBERS' HOUSE. HEEP, MR MICAWBER

HEEP: And so, Mr Micawber, my dear, dear friend, why, may I ask, did you reply to my advertisement for the post in question?

MR MICAWBER: In brief, sir, after a sojourn of several months in an establishment whose nomenclature I shall not, for political reasons reveal, I find myself deprived of a meaningful occupation which may prove even moderately remunerative.

HEEP: In brief, sir, you are newly out of the debtors' prison and, less newly, out of a job?

MR MICAWBER: In brief, sir, I would respond in the affirmative fashion.

HEEP: So what do you have to offer a business which 'as the 'umblest pretentions?

MR MICAWBER: Honesty, sir, gentility, an extensive vocabulary, a mind which knows no superior, and a certain natural modesty which perhaps leads me to understress my strong points.

URIAH: Hm... I like all but the first, Micawber. You will make an admirable front man for my operations, but I shall 'ave to teach you a little of 'Eap's honesty, 'umble honesty, and a little about veracity. What is veracity, Micawber, eh, eh? Tell me now, what is veracity?

MR MICAWBER: Veracity is the veritable truth, sir, untarnished, unblemished.

HEEP: Ah well, then, Mr Micawber we shall have to blemish it a little.

MR MICAWBER: Blemish it!

HEEP: And we shall have to tarnish it.

MR MICAWBER: Tarnish it!

HEEP: Just a little, sir, and though it stays veracity it shall be termed "false veracity".

MR MICAWBER: False veracity!

HEEP: In my 'umble opinion, this is the way to succeed in the ever so legal insurance business that you are about to join.

SONG: FALSE VERACITY

(SUNG BY HEEP AND MICAWBER, RESEMBLING LAUREL AND HARDY IN A SOFT SHOE SHUFFLE ROUTINE)

TO NARRATORS:

URIAH: But enough of my villainy for the time being. I'm not as 'umble as I used to be, David, and it hurts my pride as an 'onest man to see the rascal that was me. Now, let me see, if I remember rightly, the lovely Dora, at this point in time was about to catch you in her spider's web, was she not?

DAVID: Ah yes, Dora **(sighs)**. The lovely Dora, the elusive butterfly. It took me so long to pluck up the courage to ask for her hand in marriage, and then, almost before I could appreciate her beauty, she was gone.

URIAH: Indeed, David, indeed! But I still remember the wedding day.

DAVID: Ah yes, the wedding day, and everyone was there, including the uninvited guest.

URIAH: Uninvited guest? Why, who might that have been, I wonder?...mmm...

SCENE THREE - WEDDING SCENE

EVERYBODY HAPPY. ALL MAJOR CHARACTERS MAKING MERRY. HEEP AND MR WICKFIELD TALKING IN ONE CORNER – FRONT STAGE

HEEP: Mr Wickfield, another drink sir, just time for another! Are you happy, sir, are you happy, as I my 'umble self am happy on this day of all days?

MR WICKFIELD: Passably content, Uriah, you know passably content **(drinks heavily)**.

HEEP: Marriages make me think of marriage, Mr W. and marriage makes me think of one lady, and one lady alone, sir, your lovely daughter, the indescribable Agnes. See how beeeautifully she moves!

MR WICKFIELD: **(Chokes on his drink)!** My daughter, sir, don't be ridiculous.

HEEP: **(Turns nasty and high-handed)!** Do you remember, sir, signing this rather minor document not too long ago?

MR WICKFIELD: Documents, Uriah, I've signed hundreds of 'em, hundreds of 'em.

HEEP: Well take a look at this little beauty, sir. In my utter 'umbleness I may venture to suggest that it might occasion a change of mind on your part with regard to a certain future son-in-law, and, what is more, a certain future business partner, to wit one Uriah Heep esquire.

MR WICKFIELD: **(Chokes on drink again as he looks at document):** This can't be true, I'd never have signed this.

HEEP: Falsely true, Mr Wickfield falsely true. A bit of the old false veracity. But yes, you did sign it. Don't tear it up, I do have the necessary facsimiles. Well! May I have permission to approach your daughter?

MR WICKFIELD: You can...do what you damned well like!

HEEP: Eureka, Uriah, you're not 'umble now, my boy, you're not 'umble no more. Wouldn't your dear old mother like to see you now!

SONG: EUREKA URIAH/MATRIMONY (SUNG BY URIAH AND CHORUS)

TO NARRATORS:

- URIAH: Such a happy day, even if, for myself, it was for all the wrong reasons. But, not for the first time in your life, my dear old friend, tragedy lay not far behind.
- DAVID: Indeed, Uriah, for Dora, in spite of her eternally bright demeanour, was already, even at the time of the wedding, gradually, under the surface, falling victim to that plague of our society, the disease consumption. Rapidly, over the months she grew weaker, finding it more and more difficult to cope with the demands that life as the wife of an ambitious lawyer brought with it.
- URIAH: And though Dora fought her illness and tried so hard to keep you happy, your future together was short.
- DAVID: Yes, my dear friend, and, six months after that glorious summer's day when we married, she died and I was left a broken man, wondering what I could have done to save her - surely I should have noticed earlier that she was ill. No-one not even Agnes, could console me, and often, I would return to the room in which, so recently it seemed, I had proposed and we had laughed so much. So many voices in my head seemed to point me forward, but nothing, no-one could convince me that life was now worth living.

SONG: WISH I'D NEVER SEEN THE SUNSHINE (INCLUDING REPRISE OF "DAVID" AND SUNG BY DAVID AND CLARA)

TO NARRATORS:

- DAVID: And so, having reached in my life a level of happiness that in my late childhood I would never have thought possible, I suddenly found myself plunged into the depths of despair. No matter what anyone said to me, I was determined to blame myself for Dora's illness and death. Meanwhile you, on the other hand, Uriah, the erstwhile social inferior at whom I had so often scoffed, continued to thrive, and your business was expanding at a prodigious rate.
- URIAH: Ah yes, my 'umble false veracity had produced a truly prodigious profitability. And for a while, my good friend Mr Micawber profited in like fashion from the extremes of my generosity as his ever so umble employer.

SCENE FOUR - MR & MRS MICAWBER AND CHILDREN

(MRS MICAWBER PICKING LICE FROM HER CHILDREN'S HEADS. THERE IS A KNOCK AT THE DOOR.)

MRS MICAWBER: Are you expecting visitors at this unseemly hour, my dear Wilkins?

MR MICAWBER: Expectation, my dear, is the father of prosperity! Everything will come to he who expects. I shall open Sesame with hope that behind that door shall rest the final key to that future of which we have together so often dreamed. Come, boy, let us see what lies beyond. Let us face the sweet music of life!

(MICAWBER & ELDEST SON EXIT TO DOOR)

VOICE OF HEEP: Micawber, how uncommon pleased I am to cross your path on this fine summer's evening. May I dare to suggest entry into your fine and feathered nest. Are your fledglings well? May I come in? Thank you, thank you (**enter Micawber, Heep and Micawber junior**).

MR MICAWBBER: (**Irritated**): My dear, bid good evening to my respected patron, Mr Heep.

MRS MICAWBBER: Mr Heep, a very good evening to you. We did not expect such a visitor, did we?

CHILDREN: No, mother.

HEEP: Well, a very good evening to you all, a very, very good evening... (**changes tone**) but, Micawber, make the most of it, for you treacherous turncoat, you poisonous viper, you will from tomorrow no longer be earning the generous commission that I, in my 'umble graciousness, have been awarding you these recent months. In brief, my dear, respected sir, you are dismissed, may I say sacked, forthwith. (**General consternation**).

MRS MICAWBBER: Mr.Heep, why go to such extreme measures, surely my dear husband cannot have proved incompetent, unskilled or unsollicitious?

HEEP: On the contrary, my dear Mrs Micawber, in spite of his inherent stupidity, he has, if anything, proved extremely competent, extremely skilled, but somewhat over solicitous in certain areas. I have only this evening discovered that your dear, dear husband has been sneaking into my own personal and ever so private chamber, and tampering with documents that are for my eyes only. Unfortunately for him, the documents concerned are only of minor significance, but my beneficent trust has been so disappointingly betrayed. And so, I have no alternative but to sack the greedy, garrulous good-for-nothing.

MR MICAWBBER: You'll not take that attitude in my house, sir.

HEEP: Micawber, you dare...

MR MICAWBBER: I dare indeed, sir, I have had sufficient of your greasy ...

HEEP: Greasy?!

MR MICAWBBER: Oily!

HEEP: Oily! Again!

MR MICAWBBER: Unsavoury!

HEEP: Unsavoury?!

MR MICAWBBER: Dishonest dealings.

HEEP: I did not hear you thus complain, Micawber, when I first employed your pitiful self. Sir, you are an ungrateful wretch.

MR MICAWBBER: That is the final straw. Mr Heep, vacate my premises. An Englishman's home is his castle and in this castle you, sir, are the knave. Depart, be gone, now and forever (**seizes Heep**).

HEEP: You shall not...

MR MICAWBER: Out! Out I say!

MRS MICAWBER: **(admiringly):** Wilkins!

HEEP: Unhand me, sir!

MR MICAWBER: Out, you rascal!

HEEP: Be warned Micawber, this shall cause your final downfall. You are finished, done for. I've got enough on you...

MR MICAWBER: Out! Out! Out! **(kicks Heep out the door)**

HEEP: You've not heard the last of this Micawber. You've not heard the last of this!

MRS MICAWBER: Wilkins, my hero, never have I witnessed you in such glorious circumstances.

Re-enter Heep from other side of stage

HEEP: I repeat, you have not ...

MRS MICAWBER: Did you not hear my husband, out, out, out! **(Mrs Micawber kicks Heep out)**

MRS MICAWBER: I repeat: Wilkins never have I witnessed you in such glorious circumstances.

MR MICAWBER: **(Suddenly deflated):** My dear, you do not know what I have done. I do not know what I may yet have done.

MRS MICAWBER: Wilkins, what can this mean?

MR MICAWBER: I intend to send this Heep to prison, indeed I have taken steps to do so, but ...

MRS MICAWBER: But what, my dear husband?

MR MICAWBER: If I should have miscalculated in my efforts to expose this villain then... then... for myself...I dare not think what may happen. My dear, I fear the worst.

MRS MICAWBER: Wilkins, Wilkins, oh that it should come to this.

MICAWBER JNR: **(melodramatically, after the fashion of his parents):** Mother, Father, have you not taught us all our lives that we should at all times be positive, that we should have faith and hope. I, at least, have faith that my father shall expose this villain and hope the society shall recognise good from evil. Heep will be jailed for good and another glorious chapter will be written in the Micawber family history. Mark my words, mother, father, mark my words.

(REPRISE OF LAST TWO LINES OF “SOMETHING WILL TURN UP”

SUNG SLOWLY THIS TIME AND LED BY MICAWBER JUNIOR

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: Strange to see even Micawber, albeit temporarily, as he might say, pessimistic in spirit. And this was still a dark and worrying time for me also. Physically I was strong, but mentally I was severely troubled by the death of Dora. But Aunt Betsy again, I have to say, was my saviour, and it was to Dover that my ailing spirit once more fled in the hope of renewal. And there, in the company of the arch-philosopher Mr. Dick, I once again discovered life and once again found peace of mind.

SCENE FIVE - AUNT BETSY. ENTER MR. DICK AND DAVID

MR DICK: My kite, my kite, etc. **(exit via other side of stage)**

DAVID: Phew! You know, flying that kite is a solution to all worldly cares, Aunt Betsy. It needs all your concentration.

AUNT BETSY: Yes, people have many doubts about Mr Dick's sanity, but there's a cure for most problems in that head of his. It just needs to come out in the right order!

DAVID: If only I could be like Mr Dick. At peace with myself and with the world. He makes life seem so simple.

AUNT BETSY: But Mr Dick's had his troubles too, David. If it weren't for me, he'd have been, god forbid, in an asylum. Imagine that. A man with so much inner vision, a man who sees the important issues in life clearer than any other man I know. And yet people say he's crazy.

(RE-ENTER MR DICK, IN CRAZY FASHION), STILL WITH KITE, FOLLOWED BY A CHORUS OF VARIOUS URCHINS)

MR DICK: Crazy! Crazy!

SONG: CRAZY (SUNG BY MR DICK AND CHORUS)

AT END OF SONG ENTER MR & MRS MICAWBER (AFTER KNOCK ON DOOR)

MR MICAWBER: Copperfield, Copperfield. How marvellous to see you in more optimistic spirit. I have journeyed far and long this day in the expectation of consultation of your legalistic expertise. In short, I seek your advice.

MRS MICAWBER: Mr Micawber has a plan, David, a plan which will, he hopes, expose Heep for the fraud he really is. Having gained Heep's trust, and having given Heep the impression that he was an incompetent, babbling old fool ...

MR MICAWBER: Oh the pain, the excruciating pain of portraying my good self as an incompetent ...

MRS MICAWBER: Having gained, I say, Heep's trust, my ingenious husband obtained access to certain secret documents in Heep's inner sanctum which prove indubitably that the rascal is a cheat and a fraud.

DAVID: Indubitably?

MR MICAWBER: Indubitably!

MR DICK: Indubitably.

AUNT BETSY: Mrs Micawber. I really don't think David should be troubled. He's still not quite himself. He still has a lot of worries.

DAVID: No, Aunt Betsy. It's time I got back into real life again. I must be positive. If my talents can help nail that miserable rogue Heep then perhaps I can make a contribution to society. Perhaps there is another role in life for me to play. Come. Mr Micawber, we'll sit down and work out our case so that we can sort out that miserable fellow once and for all.

EXIT DAVID AND MICAWBER

MRS MICAWBER: It worked! It worked!

AUNT BETSY: I knew he wouldn't be able to resist the temptation to confront Uriah Heep. This is just the thing to bring our David back to his normal self. Mr Dick. Pack your bags, we're all going to London Town!

MR DICK: London Town, London Town, London Bridge is falling down, London Bridge is falling down...

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: And so to your ultimate demise, Uriah.

URIAH: I shudder to think about it, David. Get it over with! Get it over with quickly!

DAVID: Yes, Mr Micawber had done his homework well, and for once, Uriah, you had come unstuck. In considering Micawber a fool you had miscalculated quite seriously, for, beneath all his bluster, I had always suspected there lay a cunning brain. His fault had never been a lack of intelligence, it had been a lack of business acumen. As Mrs Micawber had once said, his only fault lay in his trusting people too much. But, on this occasion, he had forced himself to be quite bloody minded and the result was quite astounding.

SCENE SIX - DAVID, AGNES, THE MICAWBERS, AUNT BETSY, MR DICK, MR WICKFIELD

AGNES: But are you sure that the evidence that you have gathered is incontrovertible? If nothing else, Uriah's a shrewd devil, and if there's any sort of loop-hole, well, he'll have the whole lot of you behind bars. That much I am sure of.

DAVID: Agnes, the proof provided by Mr Micawber, aided by your good father, is certainly proof positive. We have the rascal at last.

MR MICAWBER: The trap was set, the bait was taken and the rodent was caught. A scenario much rehearsed, but seldom enacted to such infinite perfection. In short, Heep does not have a spindly leg to stand on.

MR WICKFIELD: In short the case is watertight.

AUNT BETSY: But I'll still not rest until Heep is in the good hands of the constabulary.

AGNES: Nor I.

KNOCK ON THE DOOR

AGNES: It's him. I'll let him in. **(Exit)**

DAVID: Mr Micawber, Mr Wickfield, are you prepared?

MR MICAWBER & We are!
MR WICKFIELD:

ENTER AGNES, HEEP – SURVEYS THE COMPANY

HEEP: Agnes, my beloved, you are looking as radiant as ever, but, my dear, why do you keep such low company? If you did not delay our wedding so, you wouldn't have to mix with such ... such riff-raff.

AGNES: It is the company I choose.

MR WICKFIELD: Heep! ...

HEEP: How dare you call me Heep, you bewhiskered, befuddled buffoon! If not Uriah, then be it Mr Heep, but one of the two sir, one of the two.

MR MICAWBER: Soon Heep, we shall all have a perfect right to call you whatever we may wish.

HEEP: You shall not ...

MR MICAWBER: Silence, you oily rogue, we are about to experience an oasis of pleasure in the midst of this care-ridden desert that we call our world. In short, we intend to expose you, Mr Heep, inexorably, in all your evil glory.

MR WICKFIELD: In short we have evidence.

MR MICAWBER: Queen's evidence.

MR DICK: Queen's evidence!!!

SONG: QUEEN'S EVIDENCE

(SUNG BY WICKFIELD, MICAWBER, HEEP AND CHORUS. LAST VERSE FIRST TWO LINES SUNG BY POLICEMEN WHO KNOCK PRIOR TO THE FINAL VERSE AND ENTER TO ARREST HEEP)

(END OF SONG EXIT HEEP, ARRESTED)

DAVID: And so Uriah, behind bars for you, and not before time.

URIAH: Indeed David, I had many lessons yet to learn, many lessons yet to learn and that spell in prison was the first of them.

DAVID: And meanwhile, ironically, this ill luck for you was the spark which ignited a new flame in my life as I once more discovered the will to go forward and not look back. And at last misfortune passed me by and I built steadily on a new future. And I can recall since then only one day of true sadness, when I said goodbye again to the Micawbers, now en route for Australia, and even that disappointment was countered by a happy event to parallel anything that I had so far known ...

SCENE SEVEN - DAVID, AGNES, MR WICKFIELD, BETSY, DICK, THE MICAWBERS

DAVID: Are you sure you won't change your minds at the last minute? Mr Wickfield and I can guarantee you a post if you remain in England. You can depend on that.

MRS MICAWBER: No David. It's very kind of you and Mr Wickfield, but our children need a new life, beyond all this. We need a complete break from the past, and I'm sure we're doing the right thing. The Micawbers have plumbed the depths of despair, soon we shall reach the heights of prosperity!

MR MICAWBER: The land of opportunity beckons, Copperfield. Australia, where the Micawber clan shall find its Mecca. The hitherto unrecognized and unhailed skills of Wilkins Micawber shall be appreciated and adequately rewarded. In short, penury shall be a spectre of the past. Mark my words, my old friend, you shall in time hear of the right honourable Wilkins Micawber, Justice of the Peace. New horizons shall bring new hopes, skill bring new success. In short, something, just mark my words, will at last turn up.

MRS MICAWBER: Come, Micawber, the tide at Southampton beckons.

INSTRUMENTAL REPRISE OF "SOMETHING WILL TURN UP"

MRS MICAWBER: **(Counts children as they leave stage):** We'll send on for the rest of the children later.

EXIT MR & MRS MICAWBER IN THE MIDST OF MUCH HANDSHAKING AND NOISE, DAVID AND AGNES COME FORWARD

DAVID: **(Sadly):** Good friends gone, Agnes, probably never to be seen again, the Micawbers were like my own family, you know. We've been through a lot together.

AGNES: I know, David, never mind, you've still got your favourite sister to rely on. Come on, we should be happy, I've never known Mr Micawber so changed as he's been recently. David... there's nothing wrong is there?

AGNES: Agnes, I may risk losing the best friend I ever had, but ...could ...you ...ever look upon me as someone a little more ...er ... a little more than a friend?

AGNES: David?

DAVID: Agnes, I've said before that I love you. Before it was like sister, but now it's different. Agnes...Will you marry me?

AGNES: David! Of course

REPRISE: ANGEL IN THE MORNING (SUNG BY CHOIR)

TO NARRATORS:

DAVID: And so there remains one loose end, Uriah. Even after imprisonment you continued your dishonest ways for quite a time?

URIAH: For quite a time, and we come full circle again, to Christmas, it would be Christmas wouldn't it? A Christmas when suddenly my whole life of misery seemed to flash before me and the one word which had been absent from my miserable existence imprinted itself indelibly upon my mind - love. I shall never know why this was destined to be, but something happened that day to change me once and for all.

SCENE EIGHT - CHRISTMAS SCENE - CAROL SINGERS PASS HEEP, HE SCOWLS, BUT LITTLE BOY COMES BRAVELY UP TO HIM

LITTLE BOY: You're a mean old man, Mr Heep, you may be rich, and I may be poor, but I pity you. For in my home I have love and the world is built on love and no matter how much money you've got it won't replace the love I have in my heart. But I offer you love Mr Heep. I offer it you once and if perhaps you take it you may yet, even now, be happy. But be careful, Mr Heep, for your time is running out. A very Happy Christmas Mr Heep, a very Happy Christmas.

(ONE CAROL SINGER IN THE BACKGROUND SINGS SILENT NIGHT)

HEEP: What a strange boy, and yet a voice somewhere seems to tell me that maybe...maybe... perhaps... he may have something. Did my mother, with her keenness to see me escape the abject poverty that had dogged her existence, make me lose the one thing that is most important in life? And suddenly I feel tired and I feel so old, and ... for the first time in my life I feel the need of friendship. But can a man such as I change? Can a man such as I be loved even if he has not loved others? Can a man such as Uriah Heep enjoy Christmas with the rest of the world? Can a man such as Uriah Heep find a new way of life, at this time of life? Can he? Could he? Who knows...

SONG: ONLY LOVE

SUNG BY URIAH AND CHORUS. AFTER INSTRUMENTAL BREAK, AND DURING FINAL VERSE, URIAH TAKES OFF HIS SCARF AND COAT AND SYMBOLICALLY GIVES THEM TO TWO OF THE BOYS WHO FORM PART OF A CHORUS OF POOR CHILDREN WHO HAVE ENTERED DURING THE INSTRUMENTAL BREAK.

END OF SONG FADE TO NARRATORS, WHO TAKE CENTRE STAGE

(CAROLS AGAIN IN BACKGROUND)

DAVID: And so the jigsaw is complete. And so we have turned full circle and our eventful lives are almost at an end, my dear Uriah.

URIAH: I don't know, David, I think there's still a bit of life in the old dogs yet.

DAVID: Maybe, maybe, but at least we can now look back and say that our lives have not been lived in vain. We have lived them to the full and our friends are many and valued.

URIAH: They are indeed. Far and wide, a fine company of friends, even as far as Sydney, Australia, where Sir Wilkins Micawber is I am told, the judge to avoid, unless you happen to be a man chased by creditors.

DAVID: Yes, a fine company of friends. You might in fact say that they are the real Copperfield and Company.

URIAH: I give you then David a final toast, to Copperfield and his fine Company.

DAVID: To Copperfield and Company.

SONG: COPPERFIELD AND COMPANY

(WHOLE CAST JOIN IN AS SONG BRINGS SHOW TO A CLOSE)

THE END